

G2G: Meet our Members: Michael Cayley

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Hi everyone!

1.5k views

It's time to get to know another one of our wonderful WikiTreers. This week's member is [Michael Cayley](#).

Michael became a Wiki Genealogist in August 2017 and just passed 100,000 contributions! He co-leads our [Magna Carta](#), [Medieval](#) and [Quakers](#) projects and is a Mediator, [Mentor](#) and [Moderator](#).



How did you become interested in genealogy?

Through my aunt - a physically small woman with a formidable personality, who tracked down cousins around the world, extracting family history information, and who had a cache of family letters and papers in a tin chest, dating back to the late 18th century (some of these we gave to the British Library after her death).

What are your other interests?

I'm a bit of a grasshopper, jumping between interests ranging from maths and science to history and classical music. I've had a lifelong passion for literature, of all periods and of different countries. I'd like to know more languages well enough to read more works in their original form rather than translation.

Who is your favourite ancestor?

Charles Bagot Cayley, an extremely shy, impractical, absent-minded, often disheveled, brilliant linguist of the 19th century who lived in genteel

poverty after losing money in an early venture to set up advertising hoardings at railways stations. He came to know the Rossettis, one of whom taught him Italian. He and the poet Christina Rossetti fell in love. One of Christina's brothers offered to supplement their income if they married. She was a staunch high Anglican and he was agnostic. She felt unable to marry him because of the religious differences, and sadness about this continued for the rest of her life: but they kept up a warm friendship.

Some of Christina Rossetti's poems were inspired by her love for him. Her brothers regarded him with affectionate humour, and sometimes nicknamed him the wombat.

Do you have a particularly tough brick wall?

Yes - I've never been able to take my mother's Dalton ancestry back beyond the early 19th century. They lived then in Cumberland in NW England, and Dalton is too common a surname in the area for it to be possible to extend the line back into the 18th century. There was a family belief that they were descended from the Quaker chemist John Dalton, but he did not have children - an example of the myths one can find in family traditions.

How long have you been on WikiTree? What made you join?

I joined in 2017. I was looking for a way to preserve what I had discovered about my family history.

How has your involvement in WikiTree changed?

Like many members, I now spend little time on my own ancestry. I co-lead three Projects - [Magna Carta](#), [Medieval](#) and [Quakers](#). Much of my focus is on pre-1700 and pre-1500 profiles, which appeal to my love of historical research. I have also become a Mediator, G2G Moderator and occasional mentor.

I really enjoy it when I manage to turn a profile which has evolved as a miscellany of, sometimes repetitive, information into a more coherent

fleshed-out biography. I get a big sense of satisfaction if I connect profiles up to our worldwide tree.

How can others help a Project you co-lead?

As a Brit, my emphasis for the Quakers Project has been on improving WikiTree's coverage of British Quakers. There are important families for which the coverage is incomplete or profiles could be substantially improved, and it would be great to have volunteers to work on some of them.

What do you find most attractive about WikiTree?

The way we collaborate. Our skills, interests and areas of knowledge and expertise differ, and together we create something much better and bigger than any of us could on our own.

Is there an aspect of WikiTree you would like to see improved?

More flexibility in name fields to cater better for cultures and periods for which the "first name, last name" convention is inappropriate.

Changing the way name searches operate so that they extend to names in the nickname field - this would be especially helpful for medieval profiles - and doing the equivalent for the system which pulls up possible existing profiles when you try to create a new one.

These changes may not be easy: I suspect extensive coding would be involved.

Are there examples of how you have been helped by other members?

Proof-reading some of my longer biographies: my ageing eyes make it more difficult to spot typos and minor slips, and I have been really grateful for the willing assistance of others.

The most important help I have had is when another member has concentrated my mind on the need to find better sourcing or revisit

something I have done. This can be uncomfortable, but it's really beneficial and salutary. We can all be slipshod at times.

Do you have any advice for newer members?

Do not be afraid to ask for help. G2G is a good place to do so. Don't be upset if you sometimes make mistakes - we all do. And be prepared to have some of your long-cherished beliefs proved wrong: it happens to many of us at some point.

Do you have tips for someone who wants to get more involved in our community?

Join a [project](#) and participate actively in it.

See if you can help others in G2G.

As a Mediator, I'm very conscious that there are members who would benefit from some help and support. If you are used to WikiTree and comfortable with evaluating what is good sourcing, and can be patient and understanding when others struggle a bit, do think about volunteering to be a mentor. It can be very rewarding.

What can we do to inspire more people to participate in our mission?

Tell others about WikiTree! If you belong to a family history society, consider writing something about WikiTree for its magazine, newsletter, blog or website. If you have a blog or website of your own, mention WikiTree on it.

WikiTree profile: [Cayley-55](#)

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MEET_OUR_MEMBERS

APPRECIATION

CAYLEY

[asked](#) Nov 19, 2023 in [The Tree House](#) by [Eowyn Langholf](#) GOLDEN OWL (3.1m points)

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11 Answers

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Michael, you are a WikiTree treasure. I appreciate all you continue to do as a project leader to better our shared tree and support the community. The "jobs" of mentor, mediator and moderator are individually very time-consuming and challenging. They are often thankless roles, but you continue to do all three, so we all THANK YOU! I am proud to have worked with you for so long in MCP and I am forever grateful for all you have taught me and the community about medieval and English genealogy. You are a true gem!

Best answer

[answered](#) Nov 22, 2023 by [Traci Thiessen](#) **OWL** (318k points)
selected Nov 24, 2023 by [William Maher](#)

[comment](#)

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Micheal, thanks for all you have done here on wikitree. from time to time, I have encountered your work that has benefitted my effort. Thanks again for all you do, 11c2r- Kevin

[answered](#) Nov 20, 2023 by [K Smith](#) **OWL** (520k points)

[comment](#)

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Thanks to wikitree, I can tell you i am proud to be yours 23rd cousin, Regards from Norway, but our common ancestry is in Sweden.

[answered](#) Nov 20, 2023 by [Kari Undbekken](#) **OWL** (156k points)

[comment](#)

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Michael Cayley! It is so great to see you as a Featured Member on this G2G. I cannot thank you enough for all of your help on my English ancestors. I especially admire the work that you do on Magna Carta. Your profiles are gems and your reviews of my work have been great learning experiences.

We are 18th cousins through MRCA Joan (Minshull) Hooten. Thank you for a very interesting interview and for all that you do for our Tree!

[answered](#) Nov 22, 2023 by [Carol Baldwin](#) GOLDEN OWL (1.4m points)

[comment](#)

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votes

Thank you for everything that you have worked on. You are an asset to WikiTree.

[answered](#) Nov 22, 2023 by [Kathy Nava](#) OWL (529k points)

[comment](#)

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Michael, Pleased to "meet" you, I have Ancestors from All 3 of your Projects, all, but 2 of the Magna Carta Sureties are my Relatives! Medieval, Scores, much of the Royalty & Nobility of Europe are Relatives! I admit that I've forgotten what your 3rd Area of Interest was, I'll hae to look again! Be Well, Jack MacDonald-Hilton, now from Worcester, MA, raised in Danvers, MA (Olde Salem Village).

[answered](#) Nov 22, 2023 by [Jack Hilton](#) OWL (58.7k points)

[comment](#)

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Michael, I just looked, as regards Quaker Ancestors? John Howland from the Mayflower is listed as a Quaker Surveyor, the only Known Quaker that I have! There must be Others, I never bothered much w/Religion in my Research! Jack

[answered](#) Nov 22, 2023 by [Jack Hilton](#) OWL (58.7k points)

[comment](#)

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Congratulations 12C3R Michael for being selected as WikiTreer of the week, and for your contributions to WikiTree.

Thank you, Eowyn, for selecting Michael.

[answered](#) Nov 22, 2023 by [Marion Ceruti](#) OWL (468k points)

[comment](#)

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Very clear and very interesting interview, Michael. The improvements that you suggest make sense to me. Thank you for your thousands of contributions to Wikitree! We appear to be very distantly related (16th cousins) and descended from Richard (FitzAlan) de Arundel; Richard (Worksley) de Worsley and Lorworth (Hulton) ap Bledyn all born 700 - 800 years ago! I find that 100 years has shrunk since I have grown old and have been working on genealogy and related projects.

[answered](#) Nov 23, 2023 by [Clare Pierson](#) OWL (52.0k points)

[comment](#)

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So glad to learn more about you, Michael! I enjoy working with you, and ditto what Traci said :-). Also, I checked out your relative [Rev Thomas Dalton](#) my presumed ancestral village Wetheral is just 5 miles south of Crosby-on-Eden. One of these days I'll learn enough about English records to "jump the pond" :-)

[answered](#) Nov 24, 2023 by [Elaine Martzen](#) OWL (367k points)

[comment](#)

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I really appreciate everyone who has worked very very hard in wiki tree and presenting documentation. I don't come on here as much as I'd like but I was very surprised to see how many on the Mayflower I am actually related to including the featured wiki tree person of the week!! Even though I've been doing research since 2014 and I've had many try to block and argue the HOLMAN side via EDWARD from Britain; as soon as I saw FAY (HOLEMAN) (heavily supported by A LOT OF DNA), I knew then my connection.

Words cannot express my gratitude to all of you who are very hard WORKERS & Relatives!!

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asked Aug 29, 2025 in [Appreciation](#) by [Chris Whitten](#) GOLDEN OWL (1.7m points)

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asked Dec 15, 2022 in [Appreciation](#) by [Traci Thiessen](#) OWL (318k points)

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asked Mar 24, 2021 in [Appreciation](#) by [Robert Webb](#) OWL (87.3k points)

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asked **Apr 11, 2023** in [Appreciation](#) by [Carol Baldwin](#) **GOLDEN OWL** (1.4m points)

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asked **Dec 10, 2024** in [Appreciation](#) by [Arlene Slobecheski](#) **G2G-10** (11.7k points)

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asked **Sep 22, 2023** in [Appreciation](#) by [Lucy Selvaggio-Diaz](#) **GOLDEN OWL** (1.1m points)

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CAYLEY

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asked **Jul 15, 2022** in [Appreciation](#) by [Marion Ceruti](#) **OWL** (468k points)

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asked **Aug 16, 2021** in [Appreciation](#) by [Anne Rees](#) **G2G-10** (10.6k points)

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2

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asked **Jul 7, 2021** in [Appreciation](#) by [David Hughey](#) **GOLDEN OWL** (1.8m points)

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CAYLEY

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asked **May 13, 2021** in [Appreciation](#) by [David Hughey](#) **GOLDEN OWL** (1.8m points)

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